

III. Network Security: Best Practices

Source: “Network Security Policy: Best Practices White Paper”
available at
www.cisco.com/warp/public/126/secpol.html

Without a security policy, the availability of your network can be compromised. The policy begins with assessing the risk to the network and building a team to respond. Continuation of the policy requires implementing a security change management practice and monitoring the network for security violations. Last, the review process modifies the existing policy and adapts to lessons learned.

We look here at preparation, prevention, and response, in detail.

Preparation

Prior to implementing a security policy, you must:

- Create usage policy statements
- Conduct a risk analysis
- Establish a security team structure

1. Creating Usage Policy Statements

Creating usage policy statements that outline users' roles and responsibilities with regard to security is recommended. You can start with a general policy that covers all network systems and data within your company. This chapter should provide the general user community with an understanding of the security policy, its purpose, guidelines for improving their security practices, and definitions of their security responsibilities. If your company has identified specific actions that could result in punitive or disciplinary actions against an employee, these actions and how to avoid them should be clearly articulated here.

The next step is to create a partner-acceptable use statement to provide partners with an understanding of the information that is available to them, the expected disposition of that information, as well as the conduct of the employees of your company. You should clearly explain any specific acts that have been identified as secu-